ners were in contest across 12 seats—in six, it was RJD vs Congress. The latter was contesting nine less than last time, but its cussedness on certain seats has created 10 overlapping contests. The air had turned acrid, panic was peaking.

That's when the Congress blinked, and sent former Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot as a peace emissary to Patna. He duly met Tejashwi and Lalu Prasad, and declared the alliance intact. A day later came the anointment of Tejashwi as CM face, and a withdrawal from two contests versus the RJD—the third was done by VIP. It was a breathless rescue act that may not have been needed had Tejashwi and Rahul bottled some of the camaraderie they radiated on their yatra and let it mature into the discipline of alliance-building.

The NDA Triangle

Seat-sharing was not entirely without friction for the five-party ruling coalition either, but it has managed a relatively neat arrangement. The formula: 101 seats each to the BJP and JD(U), 29 to Chirag's LJP, six each to Jitan Ram Manjhi's Hindustani Awam Morcha (HAM) and Upendra Kushwaha's Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM). But that external symmetry concealed internal antagonisms. The LJP had one nomination rejected (leaving 242 NDA candidates in the fray) but even its remaining 28 are enough to make the JD(U) see red. Why? Well, scenario-makers have painted a few trickily dynamic possibilities ahead—far from the idea of a unitary alliance.

For one, Chirag had famously gone solo last time, practically doing man-to-man marking on the JD(U), and costing it 34 victories. So, the feelings are not exactly comradely, and Nitish's loyalists harbour more than a hint of suspicion about motives this time too. What if the BJP improves upon its 67 per cent strike rate from 2020, gaining well over 70 seats, and the LJP, too, pools in a handy few? If the duo fall short of the majority mark of 122 by only 30-odd seats, and then corral together a few small parties and mutinous elements, post-poll equations could be unpredictable, with their dependence on Nitish and the JD(U) proportionately diminished.



ANI

Prashant Kishor has strikingly recused himself from the contest, but despite Jan Suraaj's frailty, his viral broadsides against the BJP have inflected the narrative

The counter-intuitive thought: the JD(U) and RJD are in direct fights in some 95 seats, so some analysts have not been above predicting one last grand political pirouette by Nitish! The logic assumes a solid chunk of 95 seats being outside the BJP's reach, plus whatever the Congress and Left bring. Given Bihar's political past, no speculation can be accused of being too wild. If nothing else, both the BJP and the JD(U) will hold aces up their sleeve to up their bargaining power.

The Caste Abacus

The social profile of candidates creates some interest. The RJD's list of 142, the largest for any party, reveals its ambition to finish as the single-largest entity. Buttressing that is a variation on Akhilesh Yadav's PDA (Pichhda-Dalit-Adivasi) formula in Uttar Pradesh—namely, expanding beyond the old Muslim-Yadav (MY) vote base with a more variegated candidate list. The RJD has 69 MY candidates among its 142—51 Yadavs and 18 Muslims. So, over half are other colours on the caste rainbow: 18 non-Yadav OBCs like Kurmi-Kushwaha, 19 Dalits, eight Vaishya, plus 14 forward castes. Notably, there are also 24 women. In Bihar, they call it 'A to Z'.

The Congress, too, has strikingly chosen to leaven its newly minted pro-social justice plank by reserving over a third of its tickets for forward castes: eight Bhumihars, five Rajputs, seven Brahmins, one Kayastha. The idea seems to be to blunt the NDA's *savarna* edge while allowing the MGB to straddle the caste alphabet elsewhere. As many as 49 of the BJP's 101 are forward caste—its traditional base that makes up only 15 per cent of Bihar's population. In fact, a third of all NDA candidates tick that box.

The Spoiler's Struggle

That leaves Prashant Kishor, the strategist turned self-styled sovereign. He entered with the swagger of a reformer, yet his Jan Suraaj is showing the frailty of a fledgling. His fiery press conferences and viral broadsides against BJP heavyweights dominate headlines, inflecting the overall narrative, but he's struggling to translate digital traction into political turf. PK has strikingly recused himself from contesting, and some of his recruits, too, seem to be reconsidering the cost-benefit of standing under his banner.

On October 21, PK alleged three of his nominees had been bullied into withdrawing their candidacy by the BJP—splashing pictures of Union ministers Amit Shah and Dharmendra Pradhan. He claims 14 others had been threatened. But the 240 in the fray could swing seats, even win a few. However, if he recedes to join the ranks of Bihar's umpteen small parties, it would be a cautionary tale of metropolitan rhetoric colliding with the rough texture of native politics. ■